Economic Aspects of Land Reform in Kiangsu, 1949-52

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Part 2: The Economic Impact of Resource Reallocation upon the Peasant Economy

The first part of this article consisted of a documentary analysis of the implementation of land reform in North and South Kiangsu between 1949 and 1952. What emerged most strikingly were the contradictions inherent in the multiple objectives of the institutional changes taking place and the impossibility of disassociating their economic and non-economic consequences. Specifically, the requirements of restoring production in the industrial sector, where many enterprises were under the control of landlords, while simultaneously redistributing landlords' agricultural land and other resources, gave rise to a serious dilemma which was reflected in different policy emphases during the campaign. Even if this dilemma could have been resolved, there remained a further contradiction: between the social and political desirability of allocating the maximum amount of land to the poorest peasants and the economic benefits to be gained from allowing the middle peasants to share in the fruits of expropriation. The situation was also complicated by the need to protect the efficient rich peasant economy, even at the expense of encouraging " capitalist " development.

In this second part of the article an attempt will be made to investigate some of the purely economic aspects of land reform in the hope that some light may be thrown on the issues raised in the earlier analysis. The questions I shall ask here are: how much land was expropriated and how many peasants gained from its redistribution? How did this reallocation affect the pattern of landholding in the province? What impact did it have on the production capacity (and so the consumption level) of different groups of peasants? Brief consideration will also be given to the distribution of factors of production other than land.

The availability and quality of data are obviously crucial considerations in this section. Statistical information is more readily available for South Kiangsu than for North and this is reflected in the space devoted to each. On the question of reliability, there seems no reason to believe that any of the figures cited here are a deliberate falsification: they are mostly taken from local newspapers and presumably reflect the best

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knowledge available to the planners at the time. Although this is in itself no guarantee of their accuracy, in view of the need to keep a constant check on the progress of land reform, there is some hope that they are not too far removed from reality.

There is however one final qualification: while one may reasonably suppose that many of the problems faced by the planners in Kiangsu were encountered elsewhere in China, it is to be emphasized that what follows is merely an attempt to show some of the implications of land reform policy in one province. Certainly, I would hope that the analysis has more general applicability, but without reference to a great deal more information for other regions this is a question which must await further research.

1. *The Confiscation and Reallocation of Land*

The most comprehensive information on the reallocation of land in South Kiangsu is contained in a report published in January 1952.[1] Although the figures cover only 24 *hsien* (out of a total of 27) it can be assumed that they are representative of the entire region. Later data are also available, but they contain ambiguities which make them more difficult to use.[2]

Statistics from the 24 *hsien* show that 7,180,537 *mou* (about 33 per cent of the total arable area)[3] were reallocated to 1,519,472 peasant households (66·73 per cent of all households). The area of confiscated land is closely in line with the findings of an investigation of 1,436 *hsiang* in 18 South Kiangsu *hsien*, which revealed that the proportion of land owned by landlords was 36·68 per cent of the total.[4]

On the assumption that the average size of peasant households in South Kiangsu was 4·12 persons,[5] the average amount of land allocated to each household and each person was as follows:

1. "Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko kung-tso ti pao-kao" ("Report of land reform work in South Kiangsu") *Su-nan jih-pao* (*South Kiangsu Daily*) (*Su-nan*) (Wusih), 1 January 1952, pp. 2–3.

2. "San-nien-lai Su-nan nung-ts'un kung-tso ti wei-ta ch'eng-chiu ("The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu during the past three years"), *ibid.* 30 September 1952, p. 2.

3. This figure is based on a total arable area of 25,680,000 *mou* for South Kiangsu (see "Agrarian Reform Exhibition in Shanghai," in *Survey of the China Mainland Press* (*SCMP*) (Hong Kong), No. 206 (31 October 1952), pp. 26–28), appropriately adjusted for the exclusion of K'un-shan, Tan-t'u and Wu *hsien*.

4. "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu." Note also that P'an Kuang-tan and Ch'üan Wei-t'ien in *Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko fang-wen chi* (*Investigations into Land Reform in South Kiangsu*) (Peking: San-lien, 1952), p. 1, cite material from 41 *hsiang* of 23 *hsien* to show that landlords owned about 40% of all land in the region.

5. Given a rural population of 10,290,000 ("Agragarian Reform Exhibition") and a total household figure of 2,495,544 ("The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu"), the average household size must have been 4·12 persons.

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Table 1: **Reallocation of Arable Land in South Kiangsu**

Total area reallocated (in *mou*)	*No. of peasant households to which land reallocated*	*Area reallocated per household* (in *mou*)	*Area reallocated per head* (in *mou*)
7,180,537	1,519,472	4·73	1·15

Source: "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu."

On average, each peasant received just over one *mou* of land (about one sixth of an acre). This figure may be compared with preliminary information on land redistribution in other provinces published in July 1951:

Table 2: **Average Per Capita Area Reallocated to Peasants in 4 Provinces** (in *mou*)

Honan	2·0–3·0
Hunan and Hupeh	1·0–2·5
South Shensi	1·5–2·0
North Shensi	4·0
Shensi (mountainous region)	10·0

Source: "I-nien-lai t'u-ti kai-ko yün-tung ti ch'eng-chiu" ("The success of the land reform movement during the past year"), *Hsin-hua jih-pao* (*New China Daily*) (*Hsin-hua*), 2 July 1951, p. 3.

In the more immediate geographical context, the same source gives the following per capita estimate for the East China region:

Table 3: **Reallocation of Land in East China** (in *mou*)

	Average area received per head
East China (Shantung, North Kiangsu, South Kiangsu, Chekiang, North Anhwei, South Anhwei)	2·0

Source: "The success of the land reform movement."

It is interesting that this figure is almost twice as high as that for South Kiangsu shown in Table 1. But it must be remembered that East China was a very large region, containing areas (like North Kiangsu and Shantung) where the man-land ratio was more favourable than in densely populated South Kiangsu. This point emerges from another report which

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stated that while poor peasants and agricultural labourers in East China received an average of between 1·5 and 2·0 *mou*, in individual areas the figure was as high as 3·0 *mou* or as low as 0·7.[6] Further, if my earlier proposition that certain parts of Kiangnan were characterized by relatively low rates of tenancy is correct, the amount of land available for reallocation would have been even more limited. In short, there is no contradiction between the East China average figure and the lower South Kiangsu estimate.

But in addition to regional variations, the figure cited in Table 1 conceals differences between classes of peasants. This is illustrated in the following table which shows the area of arable land redistributed to poor and middle peasants:

Table 4: **Reallocation of Land to Poor and Middle Peasants in South Kiangsu**

	Average area reallocated per capita (in *mou*)	*Range of reallocation* (in *mou*)	*Total area owned after reallocation (as % of average per capita arable area of a locality)*
Poor peasants (or agricultural labourers)	1·2	0·6–2·0	85
Middle peasants	1·1	0·5–1·9	120

Source: "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu."

The average area of arable land per head of rural population in South Kiangsu at this time was 2·495 *mou*.[7] Therefore, extrapolating for the whole region, on the basis of the data just presented, each poor peasant emerged from land reform with 2·12 *mou* of arable land (8·73 *mou* per household).[8] But as we already know that each member of this class received 1·2 *mou* through the reallocation of confiscated and requisitioned land, it is possible to estimate the overall impact of the agrarian reform upon poor peasants by comparing the average size of their farms before and after the land distribution had taken place:

6. "Hua-tung i-nien-lai ti t'u-ti kai-ko yün-tung" ("The land reform movement in East China during the past year"), *Hsin-hua jih-pao* (*New China Daily*) (*Hsin-hua*), 1 December 1951, p. 2.

7. 25,680,000 *mou* ÷ 10,290,000 = 2·495 *mou*.

8. 85% of 2·495 is 2·12 *mou*. Multiplying this by the average number of persons per household gives a farm size of 8·73 *mou*.

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Table 5: **Areas Held by Poor Peasants before and after Land Reform** (in *mou*)

	Per capita	*Per household* (i.e. size of farm)
Total area owned after land reform	2·12	8·73
Area received through reallocation	1·20	4·94
Therefore, size of original holding	0·92	3·79

Put another way, land reform had the effect of increasing the size of a poor peasant's farm by more than 130 per cent.

Similar calculations can of course also be made for middle peasants:

Table 6: **Areas Held by Middle Peasants before and after Land Reform** (in *mou*)

	Per capita	*Per household* (i.e. size of farm)
Total area owned after land reform	2·99	12·32
Area received through reallocation	1·10	4·53
Therefore, size of original holding	1·89	7·79

In this case, the increase in farm size was a little over 58 per cent.

Viewed in these broad terms land reform would appear to have conferred substantial benefits on middle peasants and, above all, on poor peasants and agricultural labourers, by bringing about an increase in the average size of their farms. However, two qualifications must be made. First, the increase in farm size in absolute terms was much less significant than the percentage figure may suggest: agriculture in South Kiangsu had always been characterized by small-scale farming, and land reform, far from reversing this trend, in fact exacerbated it by further reducing the average size of a holding. This is not to deny Ou-yang Hui-lin's statement[9] that even the reallocation of a tiny plot would have favourable incentive effects on a peasant who had previously owned little or no land. But it is to warn against equating such improvements in incentives with economic gains and to suggest that the advantages accruing from reallocation need to be set against the disincentive effects that could arise from other sources.

The second point is a repetition of one made earlier – that an average figure may conceal wide variations in the allocation of land between different areas. Suppose, for example, that the maximum and minimum amounts of arable land (rather than the average used in Tables 5 and 6)

9. "Speeches by various representatives" at the Second Plenum of the first session of the Conference of People's Representives from All Levels of South Kiangsu, *Su-nan*, 15 September 1950, p. 5.

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were reallocated to peasants. The impact on the farm size of poor and middle peasants would then be as follows:

Table 7: **Impact on Farm Size of Reallocating Maximum and Minimum Areas to Poor and Middle Peasants** (in *mou*)

(a) *Poor peasants*	*Minimum* (=0·6 *mou*)	*Maximum* (=2·0 *mou*)
Total area owned after land reform	2·12	2·12
Area received through reallocation	0·60	2·00
Therefore, size of original holding	1·52	0·12
(b) *Middle peasants*	*Minimum* (=0·5 *mou*)	*Maximum* (=1·9 *mou*)
Total area owned after land reform	2·99	2·99
Area received through reallocation	0·50	1·90
Therefore, size of original holding	2·49	1·09

Sources: Tables 4, 5 and 6.

Although the precise effect of reallocation in individual areas cannot be known because of lack of information, if the simplifying assumption is made that the relationship between poor and middle peasants' holdings after land reform and the average arable area per head of rural population was the same throughout South Kiangsu, it is possible to indicate what the variation in farm size would have been in Chinkiang, Soochow and Sung-chiang special districts:

Table 8: **Geographical Variations in Landholdings** (hypothetical estimates of average size of farms in 3 special districts after land reform) (in *mou*)

	Chinkiang	*Soochow*	*Sung-chiang*
Average area per head of rural population	2·63	2·12	2·57
Average per capita holding of poor peasants [a]	2·24	1·80	2·18
Average per capita holding of middle peasants [b]	3·16	2·54	3·08

Notes: [a] Assuming a poor peasant had 85% of the average per capita arable area in any locality.

[b] Assuming a middle peasant had 120% of the average per capita arable area in any locality.

Sources: Per capita arable area estimates based on total arable area and population data given in Mechanization Bureau of the Ministry of Agriculture, *Chung-kuo nung-yeh chi-hua wen-t'i* (*Problems of Agricultural Mechanization in China*) (Paoting, 1958), Table 1, p. 207.

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In theory, one could subtract the average amount of land reallocated to peasants throughout South Kiangsu from the data shown above in order to derive an estimate of the per capita holdings of poor and middle peasants *before* land reform. This might then serve as a basis for assessing the impact of land distribution on farm size in each of the three special districts. But, in practice, this would not be a valid exercise since variations in the man-land ratio and rate of tenancy led to different amounts of land being available for reallocation in each region. This was demonstrated in a number of contemporary reports: in Sung-chiang special district, for example, each landless or land-hungry peasant received between two and three *mou*, except in *hsien* such as Wusih and Yang-chung where land was scarce and per capita allocation was correspondingly reduced.[10] In Wusih 127,631 *mou* were distributed amongst 49,315 households,[11] suggesting that each household got 2·59 *mou* and each person, only 0·59 *mou*.

Conditions also varied in the urban areas. According to data published in May 1952, peasants in the Nanking suburbs would seem to have received almost the maximum possible allocation (1·71 *mou* per head).[12] By contrast, in Shanghai, 173,900 *mou* of arable land had to be shared by 255,041 peasants, giving each an average of 0·68 *mou*.[13]

But whatever the regional variations, the most striking feature to emerge is that although the poor peasants and agricultural labourers derived the greatest benefit from land reallocation, it was the middle peasants who ultimately stood to gain most from land reform. Although they received less land than the poor peasants, because their holdings were larger to start with, they continued to enjoy a substantial advantage in terms of farm size even after redistribution was completed.

In fact, one of the most interesting aspects of land reform in South Kiangsu that the data reveal is that despite the considerable initial difference in the size of farms belonging to each class, the middle peasants were allocated an amount of land that was only marginally less than that of the poor peasants. In this respect the Chinese appear to have pursued a deliberately non-egalitarian policy in the redistribution of confiscated resources. Other material, which shows that the per capita holdings of

10. "Su-nan-ch'ü t'u-kai chi-pen wan-ch'eng" ("Land reform basically completed in South Kiangsu"), *Hsin-hua*, 21 March 1951, p. 2.

11. "Wu-hsi Wu hsien t'u-kai ta-pu wan-ch'eng ("Land reform largely completed in Wusih and Wu *hsien*"), *Su-nan*, 2 December 1950, p. 2.

12. "Ch'e-ti fei-ch'u feng-chien t'u-ti suo-yu-chih" ("Thoroughly eliminate feudal landownership"), *Hsin-hua*, 12 May 1952, p. 3. On Nanking's experience see also "Liang-nien-lai Nan-ching shih ti chien-she kung-tso kai-k'uang" ("Reconstruction work in the suburbs in the past two years"), *ibid.* 1 October 1951, p. 4; and "Kung-ku t'u-ti kai-ko ch'eng-chi, fa-yang nung-min ai-kuo-chu-i ching-shen" ("Consolidate the success of land reform and promote the patriotic spirit of the peasants"), *ibid.* 5 October 1951, p. 2.

13. "Total victory in land reform in the suburbs of Shanghai," *Ta kung pao* (*Impartial Daily*), 19 December 1951.

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poor peasants relative to the overall average rural per capita arable area after land reform was lower in South Kiangsu than in other provinces, gives further support to this conclusion.[14] However, as I shall attempt to demonstrate in the following pages, this non-egalitarian policy may have been economically (if not socially) justified, given the conditions prevailing in the region.

But what was the impact of land reallocation in real terms – i.e. in terms of the extra production it yielded? In order to answer this important question I shall make the simplifying assumption that all the land owned by a peasant was sown under food grains. The effect of land reform will therefore be viewed in terms of its capacity to increase food output. This approach also makes it possible to say something about peasant consumption, since the grain data can be converted into energy yields.

There remains one major difficulty: the choice of an average food grain yield for South Kiangsu at the time of land reform. No direct information seems to be available from any contemporary source and it has been necessary to derive an estimate on the basis of a small number of observations on total output and the grain sown area. The figure resulting from these calculations is 285 *chin* per *mou*.[15]

On the basis of these assumptions, the following estimates are obtained:

Table 9: **Impact of Land Reallocation on Poor and Middle Peasants**

Area reallocated (in *mou*)	*Total food grain output* (in *chin*) [a]	*Edible weight* (in *chin*) [b]	*Edible weight* (in kg.) [c]	*Calorific content per day* (in cals.) [d]	*As % of 2,054 cals.*[e]	*As % of 1,900 cals.*[f]
(a) *Poor peasants*						
1·2	342·0	273·6	136·8	1001·45	48·76	52·71
0·6	171·0	136·8	68·4	500·73	24·38	26·35
2·0	570·0	456·0	228·0	1669·08	81·26	87·85
(b) *Middle peasants*						
1·1	313·5	250·8	125·4	918.0	44·69	48·32
0·5	142·5	114·0	57·0	417·27	20·31	21·96
1·9	541·5	433·2	216·6	1585·63	77·20	83·45

14. *Ch'ang-chiang jih-pao* (*Yangtze River Daily*), 16 December 1952, p. 2, gives the following data on per capita holdings of poor peasants relative to the per capita average arable area after land reform: Honan, 92·8%; Hupeh, 91·4%; Hunan, 92·6%; Kiangsi, 91·5%; Kwangtung, 99·2%; and Kwangsi, 87·6%.

15. The relevant observations will be found in *Su-nan*, 23 January 1950, p. 1, 3 March 1951, pp. 1 and 3; and 9 February 1952, p. 2. The yield of 285 *chin* has also been checked by extrapolating backwards from data available for the later 1950s.

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Notes: [a] Assuming an average yield of 285 *chin/mou.*
[b] Edible weight is taken as 80% of total grain output.
[c] 1 chin=0·5 kg.
[d] From the structure of grain production in Kiangsu, 1 kg. of food grain provides 2,672 cals.
[e] 2,054 cals. was considered by the Chinese Medical Association to represent an adequate diet. See O. L. Dawson, "Fertiliser supply and food requirements," in J. L. Buck, O. L. Dawson and Y. L. Wu, *Food and Agriculture in Communist China* (New York: Praeger, 1966), p. 123.
[f] In view of recent suggestions that calorific requirements have been exaggerated in the past, the figure of 1,900 cals. has been included as another criterion for an adequate diet.

What this table strongly suggests is that reallocated land in South Kiangsu was most important for its ability to *supplement* the output already being produced by the peasants. Even if a poor or middle peasant received the maximum possible allocation, this would not on its own provide a sufficiently large output to meet his food grain requirements for the year.

It has to be admitted that the assumptions which underlie the calculations in Table 9 are highly simplified. For example, members of a peasant household who were either very old or very young would require fewer calories than able-bodied persons between 16 to 60 years of age. The sex structure of the population might also be taken into account. Nor has consideration been given to the supply and calorific content of foods other than cereals and tubers, such as meat, fish and vegetables.

But against this must be set the clearly unrealistic assumption that all land owned by a peasant was sown under food grains. The conversion rate of 80 per cent may also be over-optimistic, since whatever remained in the peasant's hands after processing had to meet not only his family's consumption, but also seed requirements for future sowing and feed for domestic and draft animals. Taxes and levies by the state were of course an added burden. Finally, it is possible that the assumed average yield of 285 *chin* per *mou* may be too high.

An issue that has been ignored is that of multiple cropping: would not consideration of this factor lead one to revise any conclusions drawn from Table 9? That double cropping was well developed in South Kiangsu is not open to doubt, but before it is suggested that this factor would have totally transformed the situation, let it be remembered that the proportion of arable land under more than one crop by no means implies a correspondingly proportionate increase in total output. Even under the most favourable conditions, experiments conducted in South Kiangsu in 1956 showed that the double cropping of rice might raise yields by something in excess of 50 per cent.[16] But the successful practice

16. See Ministry of Agriculture, Department of Food Grain Production, *Shui-tao sheng-ch'an chi-shu ts'an-k'ao tzu-liao* (*Materials Relating to the Investigation of Techniques of Paddy Rice Production*) (Peking, 1956), p. 323.

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of double cropping on a wide scale was heavily dependent on the availability of crucial complementary inputs in the correct quantities. Bearing in mind that the peasants whose circumstances are portrayed in Table 9 were the least well endowed in this respect, it seems to me unlikely that making allowances for the existence of double cropping would undermine the basic argument presented above.

The real importance of the redistributed land can be seen more clearly if the potential grain output of a peasant's holding before and after land reform is compared. This will indicate more precisely the impact of reallocation upon rural production and consumption levels:

Table 10: **Production Potential (in terms of Food Grain) of Peasants' Holdings before and after Land Reform**

Average size of per capita holdings (in *mou*)	*Total food grain output* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in kg.)	*Calorific content per day* (in cals.)	*As % of 2,054 cals.*	*As % of 1,900 cals.*
(a) *Poor peasants*						
Original						
0·92	262·2	209·8	104·9	767·78	37·38	40·41
Final						
2·12	604·2	483·4	241·7	1769·23	86·14	93·12
(b) *Middle peasants*						
Original						
1·89	538·7	431·0	215·5	1577·29	76·79	83·02
Final						
2·99	852·2	681·7	340·9	2495·28	121·48	131·33

Sources: Tables 5, 6 and 9.

So far it has been assumed that the average grain yield of 285 *chin* can be applied equally to all peasants in South Kiangsu. However, the evidence suggests that because of different resource and skill endowments, the productivity of poor, middle and rich peasants was not the same. Thus, Liao Lu-yen, minister of agriculture, in 1958:

> Prosperous middle peasants have more and better land, adequate water supplies, fertilizers and draft animals and all the tools they need. They can get the agricultural work done on time and their technical standard of cultivation is relatively high. In these circumstances, their unit area yields are generally about 30 per cent higher than those of the poor peasants.[17]

17. Liao Lu-yen, "On the basis of co-operativization, go all out to fulfil the draft plan for China's agricultural development," *Hsüeh-hsi* (*Study*), No. 2 (1958), pp. 2–8.

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Extrapolating from this for the single case of Kiangsu, estimates can be made of the average yields of poor, middle and rich peasants in the province. Assuming that the average yield of 285 *chin* per *mou* is a reasonable proxy for that attained by middle peasants and that there existed a 30 per cent differential between yields of prosperous middle and poor peasants, the following index can be constructed:

Table 11: **Average Grain Yields of Different Classes of Peasants in South Kiangsu**

	Index of yields (poor peasant yields=100)	*Absolute level of grain yields* (in *chin/mou*)
Poor peasants	100	237·50
Middle peasants	120	285·00
Prosperous middle peasants	130	308·75
Rich peasants	140	332·50

If these revised estimates are used as a basis for calculations, the differential effect of land redistribution on poor and middle peasants emerges even more strikingly:

Table 12: **Production Potential of Poor and Middle Peasants' Holdings after Land Reform: Revised Calculations**

Average size of per capita holding (in *mou*)	*Total food grain output* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in kg.)	*Calorific content per day* (in cals.)	*As % of 2,054 cals.*	*As % of 1,900 cals.*
(a) *Poor peasants*						
2·12	503·5	402·8	201·4	1474·36	71·78	77·60
(b) *Middle peasants*						
2·99	852·2	681·7	340·9	2495·28	121·48	131·33

Sources: Tables 10 and 11.

A middle peasant's holding before land reform was almost as large as that of a poor peasant after confiscated land had been reallocated to him. Although land reform succeeded in narrowing the gap in farm size, in 1951–52 middle peasant farms were still more than 40 per cent larger than those of poor peasants.[18] The economic implications of this were very important, for the extra land which middle peasants acquired

18. For footnote 18 please see p. 530.

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enabled them to move from a situation in which their land was barely sufficient or even insufficient to provide for their needs to one in which not only were they able to meet their subsistence requirements but they also possessed a small cushion to protect against adventitious events. In personal terms, the benefits which the acquisition of this extra land conferred are obvious enough. But more significant in broader economic terms is the fact that it provided a surplus which for the first time may have enabled middle peasants to undertake net agricultural investment. Although the CCP could have implemented a distribution policy which narrowed even further the gap in farm size between poor and middle peasants, it seems clear that the policy actually adopted was more rational from an economic point of view. It is in this sense that the earlier remarks about the economic validity of a non-egalitarian programme of land distribution should be understood.

By contrast, the reallocation of land to poor peasants and agricultural labourers had much less economic importance. In terms of individual welfare, the doubling in their potential grain production which resulted from land reform was of course extremely significant, but if their original holdings were inadequate to support them, the data presented above indicate that even after land redistribution their position remained insecure. Even on the most optimistic assumptions they were not guaranteed that all-important surplus which might provide the vehicle for farm investment and agricultural expansion. If we assume that the gross food grain output of middle peasants (852·2 *chin*) represented the smallest amount compatible with net investment,[19] the poor peasants would have had to achieve an average yield of 401·96 *chin* per *mou* on their holdings after land reform in order to be in a position to expand their farm operations. The impossible burden of such a task is indicated by the fact that this was more than 40 per cent above the average South Kiangsu yield at the time.

To sum up, then, the effects of land redistribution were different for poor and middle peasants. Article One of the Agrarian Reform Law had looked to the establishment of individual peasant ownership of land as a means of "... setting free the rural productive forces, developing agricultural production and so paving the way for New China's industrialisation."[20] In South Kiangsu such hopes had a limited applicability. Because of the high man-land ratio only small amounts of land were

18. The difference in farm size before and after land reform (assuming an average household of 4·12 persons) was as follows:

	Before land reform	*After land reform*
Poor peasants	3·79 *mou* (100·00)	8·73 *mou* (100·00)
Middle peasants	7·79 *mou* (205·54)	12·32 *mou* (141·12)

19. This will not seem so unlikely an assumption if one bears in mind that the dietary standards shown in earlier tables in no way represent maxima. Remember too the extra-consumption requirements which had to be met.

20. *The Agrarian Reform Law of the People's Republic of China and Other Relevant Documents* (Peking: Foreign Languages Press, 1950), p. 1.

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available for reallocation to peasants. As a result the economic impact of land reform depended to a large extent on the size of their original holdings. For this reason, the favourable treatment accorded the middle peasants must be seen as a rational response to a serious economic dilemma.

But what was the effect of land reform on other classes? More exactly, what was its impact on rich peasants, for the landlords had already ceased to exist as a separate economic category? [21] The Agrarian Reform Law and subsequent pronouncements all emphasized the importance of protecting the rich peasant economy. This was founded on sound economic reasoning, for by virtue of the relatively large amounts of capital (financial and working) that they owned, the rich peasants tended to be the most efficient and productive farmers. Accordingly, they had a crucial role to play in agricultural recovery and growth during this period and it was vitally important that they should be permitted to continue their agricultural operations unimpeded.

From the January report on land reform we know that after distribution had taken place, the average holding of rich peasants was twice as large as the per capita average arable area of any locality.[22] In other words, extrapolating for all South Kiangsu, the average per capita holding of a rich peasant after land reform would have been 4·99 *mou* (and so the average rich peasant farm, 20·56 *mou*). This was not only more than twice as large as a poor peasant's farm, but also considerably bigger than that of a middle peasant. Its potential physical and energy output are shown below:

Table 13: **Production Potential of Rich Peasant's Holding after Land Reform**

Average size of per capita holding (in *mou*)	*Total food grain output* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in kg.)	*Calorific content per day* (in cals.)	*As % of 2,054 cals.*	*As % of 1,900 cals.*
4·99	1659·2	1327·3	663·7	4858·4	236·5	255·7

Sources: Tables 9 and 11.

The force of these figures is clear. In terms of production potential the rich peasants were far ahead of their nearest rivals: thanks to their

21. Actually, the landlords were permitted to own some land. Thus, Article Ten of the Agrarian Reform Law: "Landlords shall be given an equal share [of land] so that they can make their living by their own labour and thus reform themselves through labour." "Land reform largely completed in Wusih and Wu *Hsien*" states that of 144,384 *mou* confiscated, 9,326 *mou* were redistributed to landlords.

22. "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu."

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greater endowment of both land and capital, their gross grain output was 95 per cent higher than that of middle peasants. Seen in these terms, the policy of "preserving the rich peasant economy" would appear to have been not just a pragmatic concession to the exigencies of a temporary situation but rather the *sine qua non* of agricultural recovery and growth.

But what the table does not show is how far rich peasants' land was encroached upon during the agrarian campaigns. That such dispossession could take place was made clear in the various central and regional directives on land reform.[23] Indeed, although it was claimed that land farmed by the rich peasants themselves (or with the help of hired labour) had been strictly protected, it seems clear that this protection did not always extend to land that was rented out.[24] Perhaps the most revealing piece of evidence in this connection was the statement that in nine *hsien* of Sung-chiang special district ". . . during land reform 1,685,000 *mou* belonging to landlords were confiscated together with public land of various kinds *and other land rented out by peasants of a semi-landlord type* and landlords with industrial and commercial interests – making in all a total of 2,160,000 *mou* [emphasis added]." [25] In other words, 475,000 *mou* or 21·99 per cent of all confiscated land came from sources other than "agricultural landlords." [26] Since public land was not particularly important in South Kiangsu and landlords engaged in industry and trade were presumably dealt with fairly leniently, it is tempting to conclude that a significant contraction of rich peasants' holdings was taking place. On the other hand, it is important to distinguish ownership holdings and operational holdings: Article Six of the South Kiangsu regulations specifically allowed for the requisition of land which rich peasants leased out to others. In the absence of further evidence to the contrary, it may be assumed that redistribution did in fact follow this precept and that the operational holdings of rich peasants remained relatively unaffected.

It was pointed out earlier that more up-to-date information on the confiscation of land in South Kiangsu was published in September 1952. It seems appropriate, therefore, to conclude this discussion of land reallocation in the south by briefly considering these data.[27]

The later source reveals that 10,418,260 *mou* (40·57 per cent of the total arable area) were confiscated or requisitioned in South Kiangsu and that 66·7 per cent of all rural households benefited from the subsequent redistribution. If all this land had been reallocated, the average

23. See Part I, pp. 274–6 and pp. 289–90 respectively.

24. "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu" implies that some of the land in this category was requisitioned.

25. "Land reform basically completed in South Kiangsu."

26. "Land reform largely completed in Wusih and Wu *hsien*" reported that of 144,384 *mou* of land confiscated in 74 *hsiang* of Wusih *hsien*, 113,112 *mou* had been owned by landlords. The 22% of land not in their hands might serve as another proxy for encroachment on rich peasants' holdings.

27. "The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu."

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amount received by each rural household and each person would have been as follows:

Table 14: **Reallocation of Land in South Kiangsu: Another Estimate**

Total area confiscated (in *mou*)	*No. of rural households to which land reallocated*	*Average area reallocated* (in *mou*) per rural household	per head of rural population
10,418,260	1,663,779	6·26	1·52

Note: Total number of rural households is assumed to be 2,495,544 (see " The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu ").
Source: *ibid.*

These estimates are over 30 per cent higher than those used in the preceding pages. Although part of the difference doubtless lies in improved statistical coverage, it seems likely that the increase in confiscated area also reflects the discovery of hitherto untouched land which landlords had concealed. To this extent of course, the earlier calculations must be considered underestimates.

However, there remains a major obstacle to accepting the revised data in Table 14 at their face-value: namely the underlying assumption that all confiscated land was subsequently redistributed. The South Kiangsu regulations, in their treatment of " special land problems," made it clear that certain categories of confiscated land were to be retained and used under direct official supervision – for example, for purposes of construction, irrigation, agricultural experimentation and so on. Thus, the area of reallocated land was less than that expropriated and it follows that if the earlier calculations are underestimates, these later ones must be overestimates.

Nevertheless, in order to show that the earlier argument is not undermined by the later data, let us assume for the moment that the area of land reallocation in South Kiangsu was the average of the January figure [28] and that published in September: that is, 9,550,240 *mou*. Then, the average arable area allocated to each person and household in the rural population would be:

Table 15: **Hypothetical Estimate of Land Reallocation in South Kiangsu**

Total area confiscated (in *mou*)	*No. of rural households to which land reallocated*	*Average area reallocated* (in *mou*) per rural household	per head of rural population
9,550,240	1,663,779	5·74	1·39

28. Including an estimate for the three *hsien* not included in the original figure.

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This does not take account of differences in per capita allocation between poor and middle peasants. The calculations made earlier indicated that an extra 1·10 *mou* would have provided a middle peasant with a holding that was roughly commensurate with net investment. For the sake of argument, suppose that middle peasants' farms were unaffected by the discovery of the "new" land so that its benefits accrued wholly to the poor peasants, raising the average area reallocated to each of them to 1·68 *mou*.[29] With their original 0·92 *mou* included,[30] this gave them a final holding of 2·60 *mou* and yielded the following production potential:

Table 16: **Production Potential of Poor Peasant's Hypothetical Holding after Land Reallocation**

Average size of per capita holding (in *mou*)	*Total food grain output* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in kg.)	*Calorific content per day* (in cals.)	*As % of 2,054 cals.*	*As % of 1,900 cals.*
2·60	617·5	494·0	247·0	1808·18	88·03	95·17

Sources: Tables 9 and 11.

Even if the poor peasants received the full benefit of the increased availability of confiscated land, their final holdings were still unable to provide the all-important surplus which might permit net farm investment and agricultural growth to get under way. Indeed, with average yields of 237·5 *chin* per *mou* a poor peasant needed 3·59 *mou* before he could achieve the same gross output as a middle peasant. Without the sacrifice of most of land reform's potential economic gains, reallocation to poor peasants on this scale was simply not possible in South Kiangsu.

A priori reasoning would suggest a higher per capita land distribution to peasants in North Kiangsu than in the South. This is borne out by the limited statistical information available for this part of the province. In December 1951, for example, the vice-chairman of the North Kiangsu Land Reform Committee stated that between 40 and 60 per cent of the region's total arable area had been confiscated to the benefit of 60–70 per cent of the rural population.[31] From these figures the following

29. There are obvious objections to such simplistic assumptions: for example, presumably middle peasants *did* benefit from the confiscation of the newly discovered land. And the figure of 1·68 *mou* is a simple unweighted average (1·68 + 1·10 ÷ 2 = 1·39), whereas the greater number of poor peasants (relative to middle) would have depressed the average amount of land available to the former. But at least such restrictive assumptions will serve to strengthen the argument in the text. 30. See, above, Table 5.

31. "Su-pei-ch'ü i-nien-lai t'u-ti kai-ko yün-tung ti pao-kao" ("Report on land reform work in North Kiangsu during the past year"), *Su-pei jih-pao* (*North Kiangsu Daily*) (*Su-pei*) (Yang-chou), 28 December 1951, p. 1.

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estimates of the total area of confiscated land and number of peasant recipients are derived:

Table 17: **Confiscation and Reallocation of Land in North Kiangsu**

Total rural population:	18,776,370 [a]
	60% = 11,265,822
	70% = 13,143,459
Total arable area:	50,000,000 *mou* [b]
	40% = 20,000,000 *mou*
	60% = 30,000,000 *mou*

Sources: [a] My own estimate, based on a detailed examination of population data for Kiangsu between 1949 and 1957. See especially "Looking at the population problem from the standpoint of Kiangsu's population density," *Wen-hui pao* (Shanghai), 21 March 1957, p. 2. Also *Hsin-hua*, 5 and 15 January 1958, p. 1 and p. 2 respectively. Data in *Chieh-fang jih-pao* (*Liberation Daily*), 23 July 1950, would suggest a figure of about 18,000,000, which lends further support to the estimate shown above.

[b] "Su-pei t'u-ti kuan-hsi ti chin-hsi ("Land relations in North Kiangsu now and in the past"), *Su-pei jih-pao* (*North Kiangsu Daily*) (*Su-pei*) (Yang-chou), 30 June 1951, p. 4.

If one continues to assume an average household size of 4·12 persons, the range of per capita and per household allocation of land can now be shown:

Table 18: **Reallocation of Land per Household and per Head of Rural Population in North Kiangsu**

Total area confiscated (in *mou*)	*No. of rural households to which land reallocated*	*Average area reallocated* (in *mou*) per rural household	per head of rural population
20,000,000	11,265,822	1·78	7·33
	13,143,459	1·52	6·26
30,000,000	11,265,822	2·66	10·96
	13,143,459	2·28	9·39

Sources: As for Table 17.

In every case the average amount of land reallocated to each peasant is higher than in South Kiangsu.[32] The same fact emerges from another contemporary report that each peasant in North Kiangsu received between

32. The problem of equating land confiscation and reallocation is also present in the data for North Kiangsu. However, because of the less varied pattern of land use in the North one would expect "special land" to have been of less importance. It is interesting, for example, that the North Kiangsu land reform regulations contained no section on the treatment of special land problems.

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1·0 and 2·0 *mou* through redistribution. Regional variations were, however, considerable: in areas with a low rural population the figure was as high as 4·0–6·0 *mou*; elsewhere it was only 0·8–1·0 *mou*.

But if the peasants of North Kiangsu appear to have benefited more from land reform than those in the South, a glance at the implications in real terms (i.e. in terms of the extra output which the reallocated land could provide) will show that the advantage was illusory. This is illustrated in the following table which attempts to estimate the production potential of reallocated land in North Kiangsu on the assumption that the average grain yield there was 150 *chin* per *mou*[33]:

Table 19: Production Potential (in terms of Food Grain) of Reallocated Land in North Kiangsu

Average per capita area reallocated (in *mou*)	*Total food grain* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in *chin*)	*Edible weight* (in kg.)	*Calorific content per day* (in cals.)	*As % of 2,054 cals.*	*As % of 1,900 cals.*
1·0	150·0	120·0	60·0	439·23	21·38	23·12
2·0	300·0	240·0	120·0	878·47	42·77	46·24

Source: As for Table 9, except average grain yield is here assumed to be 150 *chin*.

Because of more favourable natural conditions and higher fertility, land productivity was higher in South than in North Kiangsu. Although the average area of land reallocated to each peasant was only 1·15 *mou* in the South, in order to produce the same quantity of food grains north of the Yangtze 1·72 *mou* were required. Unfortunately, no overall per capita estimate can be made for North Kiangsu and so it is impossible to compare the impact of land redistribution in the two halves of the province. However, the fact that three of the four per capita figures in Table 18 are greater than 1·72 *mou* might indicate that the higher fertility of the South was offset by an increased availability of land in the North. What is more clear is that only those peasants who received much more than the simple average per capita area could hope to produce a surplus for investment purposes.

It is a pity that lack of data make it impossible to analyse the production effects of agrarian policy in the North in the same detail that is possible for the South. However, this is partly compensated for by some interesting information on changes in the class composition of North Kiangsu's rural society following land reform. Although the three

33. This is slightly higher than the yield of 139·29 *chin* which can be obtained from information given in "Su-pei-ch'ü i-chiu-wu-i nien nung-yeh sheng-ch'an chi-hua kang-yao" ("Summary plans for agricultural production in North Kiangsu in 1951"), *Su-pei*, 20 February 1951, p. 2.

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examples which follow are unlikely to be wholly representative, they nevertheless throw interesting light on the kind of class reorganization that was taking place.

The first example concerned a village in Nan-t'ung *hsien*.[34] Prior to land reform it had contained 16 agricultural labourer and 46 poor peasant households. Yet after the completion of land redistribution every one of them was said to have risen to middle peasant status. What is more, this experience was said to be representative of the entire *hsien*.

A similar pattern was observable elsewhere. In a village of Pin-hai *hsien* the class composition of 158 resident households before land reform was as follows:

Table 20: **Class Composition of a Village in Pin-hai *hsien* before Land Reform**

	No. of households
Poor peasants	88
Middle peasants	29
Rich peasants	6
Landlords	5
Total	128

Source: "On the victorious foundation of land reform lead the peasants."

The discrepancy of 30 households is not explained: perhaps they represented the agricultural labourers in the village. In any case, following reallocation the situation changed dramatically, the number of poor peasant households falling to 18 while that of middle peasants rose to 137. If the three households unaccounted for were rich peasants, it is interesting that the number in this category had fallen by half.

Finally, there was the case of an unnamed village in the newly-liberated region of North Kiangsu. Here 45 per cent of those who had previously belonged to the poor peasant category subsequently rose to become "prosperous middle peasants" (*fu-yü chung-nung*).[35]

On the evidence of these examples, the land reform movement certainly succeeded in raising a large number of poor peasants into the middle peasant category: it was indeed bringing about "middle peasantization."[36] However, leaving aside the question of their representativeness, care is needed in interpreting the significance of these social changes. One of the main arguments of this article is that land reform, while un-

34. "Tsai t'u-ti kai-ko sheng-li ti chi-ch'u shang yin-tao nung-min chi-hsü ch'ien-chin!" ("On the victorious foundation of land reform lead the peasants to continue their advance!"), *Su-pei*, 30 June 1952, p. 2.

35. *Ibid.*

36. The phrase is used by John Wong in his *Land Reform in the People's Republic of China* (New York: Praeger, 1973), p. 173 *et seq.*

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doubtedly bringing personal benefits to individual poor peasants, nevertheless deliberately maintained a significant size differential between their holdings and those of middle peasants. It may therefore be asked whether there was not a contradiction between this policy and the process of "middle peasantization" that was also apparently under way. The answer, I believe, is given by the data already presented, for they indicate that the two superficially conflicting trends can be reconciled. On the one hand, the holding of a poor peasant after land reform was larger than that of a middle peasant before reallocation (see Tables 5 and 6); in this sense, land reform was having the desirable effect of "middle peasantizing" rural society. On the other hand, the position of middle peasants was not static: on the contrary, if the Chinese data are to be believed, they were also "moving upwards" and thereby approaching the point at which they could begin to make a positive contribution to agricultural growth. In this way, it could be claimed that land reform was reducing rural class stratification, but without sacrificing its broader economic objectives – a sacrifice which would have been necessary, had a more egalitarian pattern of redistribution been implemented.

2. *The Confiscation and Reallocation of other Resources*

Land was not the only factor affected by the reform programme of 1950–52, for the Agrarian Reform Law also called for the confiscation and reallocation of ". . . draft animals, farm implements and surplus grain of the landlords and their surplus houses in the countryside."[37] Indeed, in economic terms, the redistribution of resources such as tools and draft oxen was hardly less important than that of land itself, since the efficient operation and future growth of agriculture depended on the availability of all three.

There is scant information on the redistribution of landlords' surplus grain in Kiangsu, though presumably this was one of the earliest acts of the land reform campaign. In theory, it was to be used by the peasants for productive purposes – that is, as seed. However, in view of the general food shortage occasioned by recent natural disasters it seems more likely that it was simply consumed.[38] In any case, the amount of surplus grain available for redistribution in South Kiangsu (something in excess of 133 million *chin*) was inadequate for economic purposes.[39] If it had been allocated on a simple per capita basis to every peasant who subsequently received land, each person would have had a mere 19·5 *chin*; for this reason, a more restrictive policy was adopted whereby

37. *Agrarian Reform Law*, p. 1.

38. The shortage of grain in South Kiangsu is indicated by the government's relief operation in sending 93·2 million *chin* of rice to the area. See "Mu-ch'ien Su-nan sheng-ch'an chiu-tsai ti ch'ing-shih ho jen-wu" ("The current situation and the tasks of production relief in South Kiangsu"), *Su-nan*, 11 April 1950, p. 1.

39. The figure is taken from "The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu." Data for North Kiangsu are not available.

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each recipient was given a maximum of 500 *chin* of grain.[40] If this maximum allocation had been strictly implemented, little more than a quarter of a million peasants (about 2·6 per cent of the rural population) would have benefited. Even allowing for the fact that not every peasant would have received the maximum, the impact of grain distribution can only have been of peripheral economic importance.

But more serious was the situation regarding the supply of the two most important items of agricultural working capital, draft animals and tools. Throughout South Kiangsu only 33,700 draft animals were confiscated from landlords and yet, in theory at least, these had to meet the needs of 1,663,779 households.[41] In other words, each confiscated draft animal had, in theory, to serve 49·37 rural households or 203·4 peasants.[42]

Seen in this light it is obviously no coincidence that the creation of Mutual Aid Teams was already under way before the formal completion of land reform. But this only promised a partial solution to the problem, for no matter how efficient the system of sharing might be, only an absolute increase in their numbers could ultimately eliminate the gap between animal requirements and availability. This can be demonstrated fairly simply: if the average area of land reallocated to each rural household in South Kiangsu was 4·73 *mou* [43] and each confiscated draft animal had to serve 49·37 households, the burden of (reallocated) land per head of (reallocated) draft animals will have been 233·5 *mou*. The economic implications of this figure can be seen when it is set against the work capacity of animals. For example, one estimate suggests that the maximum amount of work that could be performed by a draft animal during the peak demand period was 24–34 *mou* during spring and 12–17 *mou* in summer [44]; in another source the maximum burden for the *whole* of Kiangsu was said to be about 30 *mou*.[45] On this basis, if reallocated animals alone are considered, the gap between availability and require-

40. "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu." Seed requirements were about 365 *chin* per person per year.

41. The number of confiscated draft animals is taken from "The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu" and the 1,663,779 households are simply those to which land was redistributed. It is true of course, that the confiscated animals represented only a relatively small proportion of the total supply and to this extent the calculations that follow exaggerate the true situation. However, as I shall show below, even when this is taken into account, a grave draft animal deficiency still existed.

42. Since agriculture was still family-based at this time, the household figure is the more useful.

43. See above, Table 1.

44. K. R. Walker, "Organisation of agricultural production" in A. Eckstein, W. Galenson and T. C. Liu (eds.), *Economic Trends in Communist China* (Chicago: Aldine, 1968), p. 413.

45. "Mobilize the Kiangsu Party and strive to fulfil the Twelve Year Plan for agricultural development ahead of time," *Hua-tung nung-yeh k'o-hsüeh t'ung-pao* (*East China Agricultural Scientific Bulletin*), No. 2 (February 1958). Notice that the figure of 30 *mou* overestimates the capacity of animals in the south, where the cropping system made the burden heavier.

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ments was of staggering proportions. And even when those already owned by peasants are included, a serious deficiency remained. In 1951, for example, the total draft animal population of the entire province was 1·79 millions,[46] implying an average per capita burden of 51·77 *mou*. If this is compared with the maximum capacity of 30 *mou* cited earlier, it will be seen that Kiangsu's supply of animals was still around 40 per cent below the required level. When it is borne in mind that this supply was further reduced by the number of beasts unfit for work and that, in any case, most animals were owned by rich peasants, it is clear that the difficulties faced by poor and middle peasants were even greater than this gap suggests. It seems safe to conclude that the case of a South Kiangsu village where the deficiency of animals was overcome by the simple expedient of organizing the peasants to pull the ploughs themselves [47] was one that was repeated throughout the province.

A factor which exacerbated the factor shortage was the slaughter of draft animals by landlords. Although no precise data are available to show the extent of these killings, they were frequently cited as part of the sabotage carried out by landlords and the experience of later collectivization campaigns suggests that they may have reached quite serious proportions. Illegal sales of animals and disease caused by inadequate care further aggravated the situation.[48]

A final qualification is that no account has been taken of regional variations. Unfortunately only fragmentary information is available for individual areas and this is reproduced below. The situation which it reveals is much in line with the general picture suggested above.

Table 21: **Reallocation of Draft Animals in South Kiangsu**

	Total no. confiscated	*No. of peasants to whom animals reallocated* [a]	*Availability of animals per household*	*No. of households per animal*
Nanking suburbs [c]	347	65,172	0·0206	46
Nanking suburbs [d]	374	65,172	0·0247	42
Nanking suburbs [e]	606	20,463 [b]	0·0284	34
Shanghai suburbs [f]	135	255,041	0·00206	459
Wusih *hsien* [g]	109	49,315 [b]	0·00206	452

46. "The role of Kiangsu agriculture in the development of the Great Leap," *Ti-li chih-shih* (*Geographical Knowledge*), no. 6 (1959), p. 247.

47. "Tsu-chih jen-li la-li" ("Organizing manpower to pull ploughs"), *Hsin Su-chou pao* (*New Soochow Daily*), 24 May 1950, p. 2.

48. See "Keng-niu szu-wang sheng-ping hsien-hsiang yen-chung" ("Draft cattle deaths and animal disease reach serious proportions"), *Su-nan*, 13 June 1951, p. 2. Also "Chin-tsai keng-niu fang-chih ch'u-ping" ("Prevent the slaughter of draft cattle and animal disease"), *Hsin-hua*, 20 March 1951, p. 2, which stated that in the Nanking suburbs the slaughter of cattle rose five-fold between March and September.

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Notes: [a] Peasants benefiting from land reallocation are assumed also to have benefited from the redistribution of draft animals.
[b] These figures are for households. For purposes of conversion, average household size is again assumed to be 4·12 persons.
Sources: [c] "Reconstruction work in the suburbs during the past two years," *Hsin-hua*, 1 October 1951, p. 4.
[d] "Consolidate the success of land reform and promote the patriotic spirit of the masses," *ibid.* 5 October 1951, p. 2.
[e] "Thoroughly eliminate feudal landownership," *ibid.* 12 May 1952, p. 3.
[f] "Total victory in land reform in the suburbs of Shanghai," *Ta kung pao*, 19 December 1951.
[g] "Land reform largely completed in Wusih and Wu *hsien*," *Su-nan*, 2 December 1950, p. 2. The data shown are for 74 *hsiang*.

The reallocation of tools can be dealt with more briefly. Throughout South Kiangsu, 1,768,368 farm implements were expropriated.[49] On the assumption that all who benefited from land redistribution were eligible to receive other confiscated factors, this would have provided each household with a theoretical 1·06 tools. Since many peasants (including those in the poorest category) presumably already owned a few basic tools of their own, it seems clear that the relatively small number available for redistribution posed a less serious problem than the shortage of draft animals. Nevertheless, it would be interesting to know exactly what kind of tools were available and in what quantities. A farm implement could mean anything from the crudest hoe or plough to something quite complicated and some items must have had a much higher scarcity value than others. One might therefore modify the conclusion: even if most peasants had a set of basic tools at their disposal, the shortage of more "sophisticated" equipment (water-wheels, rice-husking machines, chain pumps and so on) continued to constrain agricultural production activities, necessitating more sharing arrangements or a greater labour input in agricultural work.

Conclusion

It was to be expected that the chief economic benefits of land reform in Kiangsu would be an improvement in incentives (brought about by the granting of "land to the tillers") and a more efficient allocation of land and other factors. Since land reform tended to reduce the average size of farms, the positive economy of scale effects which in theory might also have been forthcoming from a programme of land redistribution were not in fact achieved.

From the point of view of incentives, the reallocation of land and other resources could not fail to have favourable effects. However, such benefits were of limited value if the means to realize the improved incentives were lacking. I have argued above that although land was allocated to large numbers of peasants, the per capita amounts available

49. "The great achievements of rural work in South Kiangsu."

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for redistribution were frequently too small to permit the farmer that surplus which was essential to subsequent agricultural expansion and growth. Even if the acquisition of a tiny plot was of great moment to a peasant who had previously owned little or no land of his own, in terms of the broader agricultural economy the event was much less significant. In fact, only middle peasants who already possessed sufficiently large holdings of their own were in a position to take advantage of the economic potential offered by land redistribution and undertake net investment.

If there was insufficient land available for reallocation in Kiangsu, it would be tempting to argue that one of the most serious failings of land reform was that, in the attempt to effect an even distribution of a scarce factor (land), its potential economic benefits were dissipated. However, such an interpretation is not supported by the facts. It is true that land reform in Kiangsu was egalitarian to the extent that very similar amounts of land were distributed to poor and middle peasants. But when their original holdings are taken into account, the effect was not to bring about an equal pattern of landholding at all: on the contrary, the average middle peasant's farm remained more than 40 per cent larger than that of his poor counterpart. The inference we have drawn from this is that in the interests of economic growth, the planners were prepared to sacrifice some of land reform's potential social gains. Indeed, as early as July 1950, Jao Shu-shih, speaking at the Second Plenum of the East China military administration, recognized that the poor peasants were bound to suffer in consequence of a policy which did not make them the exclusive beneficiaries of agrarian reform.[50] Although this statement was made with explicit reference to the preservation of the rich peasant economy, the data presented in this article suggest that a similar economic pragmatism which showed preferential treatment to middle peasants served to aggravate the post-land reform difficulties of the poor peasant class.

Further evidence of emergent problems in the agricultural sector following land reform is afforded by a report made in February 1951 by Kuan Wen-wei at a specially convened conference of *hsien* leaders in South Kiangsu.[51] Two of the problems were the direct consequence of poor implementation of the agrarian policies: the compulsion on rich and middle peasants to make loans [52] and the violation of the principles

50. "Report by Jao Shu-Shih at the second plenary session of the ECMA Commission," Shanghai, 14 July 1950, translated in *Current Background* (Hong Kong), No. 10 (29 September 1950). Jao was chairman of the ECMA at this time.

51. Kuan was director of the South Kiangsu's People's Administrative Office until November 1952 and chairman of the conference. His report can be found in "Kuan-yü i-chiu-wu-ling nien nung-yeh sheng-ch'an ti chi-pen tsung-chieh yü i-chiu-wu-i nien nung-yeh sheng-ch'an kung-tso ti pao-kao" ("Report summarizing agricultural production in 1950 and concerning agricultural production work in 1951"), *Su-nan*, 3 March 1951, p. 3.

52. Similar tendencies were noted in the more general context of East China. Thus, rich peasants were reported to have commented (revealingly) that ". . . the

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governing the hiring of labour. This last was causing a ". . . lack of unity between capital and labour . . . ," said Kuan, and together with the practice of enforced loans was having an adverse effect upon the production enthusiasm of the rich peasants.[53]

In addition, Kuan referred to the difficulties which had arisen from the shortage of factors other than land, admitting that despite the redistribution of landlord property, the lack of seeds, fertilizer, draft animals, tools and rations for the spring ploughing period remained a serious problem for many poor peasants. Others, such as the dependants of " revolutionary martyrs," orphans and widows, lacked labour to cultivate their land and unless they received help their farms were in danger of becoming neglected and overgrown with weeds. The prescription offered for all these ills was the same – organization. Mass movements to collect fertilizer should be launched; efforts made to repair and increase the number of tools; above all, mutual aid would provide the means whereby factor shortages were overcome.[54]

Elsewhere an investigation of conditions of agricultural production in South Kiangsu revealed that inadequate communications between the local cadres and peasants was also giving rise to tensions within the rural sector.[55] The former were criticized for their tendency to take things easy once the reallocation of land had been completed. They failed to explain the new production policies, believing instead that ". . . the poor peasants are overjoyed to receive land; in order to fill their stomachs they will naturally work hard." [56] This was clearly a miscalculation, for as the same report continued:

cadres arranged loans but do not arrange repayment." See *SCMP*, No. 141 (24 July 1951), p. 25.

53. " Report summarizing agricultural production in 1950." It is interesting that Jao Shu-shih's July 1950 speech contained some prophetic remarks about the difficulties that might arise in hiring labour after land reform: " Disputes between employers and farm labourers who continue such labour should be solved according to the measures adopted in solving labour-capital disputes in cities and on the principle of benefiting labour and capital and developing production. We must constantly keep in mind the interests of farm labourers, look after their livelihood and . . . raise their political consciousness and cultural standard. On the other hand, we must patiently educate the farm labourers to prevent ' leftist ' sentiment and deviation. No demand must go beyond the scope permitted by the present economic situation. If they exceed the scope, nobody will employ farm labourers . . ." (" Report at ECMA Commission ").

54. Concern over similar problems was echoed in reports coming out of North Kiangsu. See, for example, " Liang-nien-lai Su-pei nung-yeh sheng-ch'an ti ch'eng-chiu " (" The achievements of North Kiangsu in agricultural production during the past two years "), *Su-pei*, 10 October 1951, p. 3. Also " Report on land reform work in North Kiangsu during the past year," *ibid.* 28 December 1951, p. 1.

55. " Many problems are still arising in production," *Chieh-fang jih-pao*, 1 June 1951, p. 7. The investigation was conducted by representatives of the South Kiangsu Land Reform Committee in 25 *hsiang* throughout the region.

56. *Ibid.*

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The peasants still show an attitude of dependence on the government, believing that the People's administration will never let them starve. They demand loans of food-stuffs, seeds and fertilizer. The middle peasants are afraid of improving their position; the rich peasants dare not hire help; and the poor peasants hesitate to make plans for fear of an increase in their burden.[57]

Predictably, the rich peasants felt themselves to be in a particularly vulnerable position. In Ch'ang-shu *hsien*, for example, the redistribution programme left them prey to a number of anxieties. On an economic level, they were concerned that their legal right to engage hired labour would be encroached upon, that they would be forced to make loans to less well-off peasants and that their tax burden would be increased.[58] In addition, they were afraid that old " exploitative accounts " would be settled and that a second land reform would take place in which they were attacked and dispossessed. In these circumstances, it is not surprising that they attempted to take preventive action: in one case, some were reported to have got rid of their surplus grain so that they should not have to release it, in the form of loans, to their poorer neighbours; in another, it was stated that of 53 rich peasants who had hired outside help before land reform, not one continued to do so after the redistribution programme had been implemented.[59]

A major finding of the South Kiangsu investigation was that production difficulties persisted after land reform, sometimes exacerbated by the previous year's poor rice harvest. In one village of Lieh-yang *hsien*, said to be representative of the hilly region of South Kiangsu, all 15 poor peasant households were faced by acute problems of subsistence and only three middle peasant families managed to avoid such difficulties. In another case, more than 60 per cent of all households were in need of seeds. And in Lu-chao *hsiang* (Chiang-yin *hsien*) 18 households were without rice seeds, nine were short of farm tools and 11 ". . . lacked even the basic necessities of life." [60]

It was admitted, too, that shortages of draft animals and implements were common. Investigations in K'un-shan *hsien* showed that 70 per cent of the agricultural labourer households were in need of draft animals, irrigation wheels and even ploughs and harrows. Some 581 poor peasant families lacked a total of 61 draft animals, 46 boats, 57 irrigation wheels and 59 ploughs. In the face of deficiencies of this magnitude, simple economy measures could achieve little. Instead emphasis was placed on the short-run need to enforce a correct labour policy, to eliminate the fears of those peasants who had sufficient resources to make loans and to restore credit channels based on the principles of free negotiation and mutual agreement.

But even if such action could meet the needs of the immediate situation, did it provide a sufficient basis for policy in the longer run?

57. *Ibid.*
58. *Ibid.*
59. *Ibid.*
60. *Ibid.*

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It was evident that land reform had not on its own provided the means to rapid or sustained agricultural growth. The scarcity of essential factors of production, the small and fragmented farms and the conflicting responses of each group of peasants – all threatened to undermine any attempt to increase agricultural production within the existing technological and organizational framework. Two choices lay before the planners. Either they could implement further institutional change in the hope that more centralized planning and management permitted by larger farming units would generate more rapid growth; or they could carry out an investment programme based on the increased supply of modern inputs to the agricultural sector. Events soon showed which alternative had been chosen: by the end of the land reform movement, the establishment of Mutual Aid Teams was well under way in both North and South Kiangsu.

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